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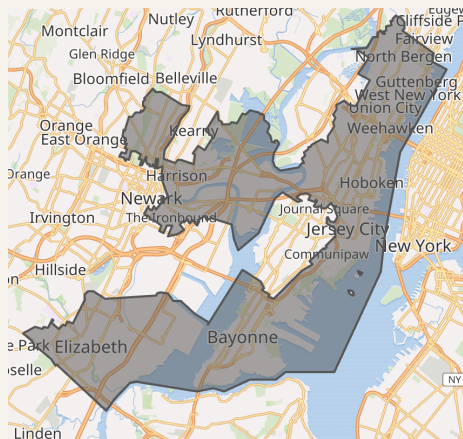
May 4, 2026

Eric Conner

Candidate Surveys, Elections

Candidate Surveys, Democratic
Primaries, New Jersey, NJ-08

Ali and Menendez in NJ-08 Answer the Better Blocks Questionnaire



Mussab Ali



Rep. Rob Menendez Jr.

Mussab Ali and Rep. Rob Menendez are facing off in the June 2 Democratic primary to represent NJ-08 in the U.S. House of Representatives. Both candidates took time to answer our questions on how they would work in Congress to resolve issues related to housing, transit, street safety, and parks for the residents of this congressional district.

Their unedited responses are reproduced below and displayed side-by-side for our readers to compare.

NJ-o8 Congressional Questionnaire

Side-by-side candidate responses for the **June 2, 2026 Democratic primary**. Challenger **Mussab Ali** and incumbent **Rep. Rob Menendez Jr.** on housing, transit, street safety, and parks.

KEY DIVERGENCES

- Q5 NEPA reform Q7 PATH oversight
- Q8 Penn Station through-running
- Q10 NJ Transit funding
- Q13 Highway funding conditions

SECTION I

Housing

Q1 Do you support increasing the federal Low-Income Housing Tax Credit (LIHTC) allocation, and should the per-capita cap be indexed to construction cost inflation? If so, by how much would you expand it?		
Ali ✓ Support		Menendez ✓ Support
MUSSAB ALI Expanding the federal LIHTC allocation is an easy step toward addressing our housing crisis, and yes, the per-capita cap should be indexed to construction cost inflation. As rents		REP. ROB MENENDEZ JR. Our country's affordability crisis is fundamentally driven by a severe housing shortage that has increased both rental and ownership prices.

cost inflation. As rents in Jersey City and Hoboken continue to push working families out of the communities they built, we need every available federal tool to accelerate the production of affordable housing. LIHTC has a strong track record of financing affordable units that the private market alone will not produce, and allowing the cap to erode in real terms over time undermines that effectiveness. I support a substantial expansion of the credit alongside indexing to ensure it keeps pace with actual construction costs, so that the financing available today is not worth significantly less in five years.

preventing families from building stability or saving for the future. While federal and state governments have a range of affordability tools at their disposal, those efforts will fall short if we do not significantly increase the overall supply of housing.

The LIHTC has the potential to be one of our most effective federal tools for producing affordable housing, but inflation in relevant sectors has eroded the efficacy of this tool over time. While the cap is already indexed to inflation broadly, the LIHTC is uniquely connected to construction costs, and inflation in that sector often grows faster than the CPI. That's why I'm supportive of House proposals that would raise the cap, including proposals that specify a 50 percent increase in the LIHTC allocation.

I also agree that program efficacy could be improved if the per-capita cap were to be indexed to construction cost inflation. At a minimum, the LIHTC should align with a construction cost index to fully account for year-over-year increases in

	construction costs. I'm also open to considering a modest index floor that provides baseline stability while allowing for more significant increases when needed. Together, these changes could better allow the LIHTC program to meet the urgent housing needs facing communities like ours.
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Q2 Housing Choice Vouchers (Section 8) currently serve only about 1 in 4 eligible households nationwide. Do you support making vouchers an entitlement for all eligible households, or do you support incremental expansion?	
Ali ✓ Entitlement	Menendez ✓ Entitlement
MUSSAB ALI That only 1 in 4 eligible households receives a voucher is a policy failure, not an inevitability. Housing vouchers are one of the most direct tools we have to help low-income families access stable housing, and rationing them through a lottery system means millions of eligible households are simply left out. I support making vouchers a true entitlement for all eligible households. Incremental expansion, while better than	REP. ROB MENENDEZ JR. We established Section 8 Housing Vouchers to meet an urgent need for stable affordable housing for low income families. But since the program's conception, underfunding has prevented Section 8 from making good on that promise. That's why I strongly believe that Section 8 Vouchers should be an entitlement for all eligible households, and I cosponsored legislation that would do just that: Rep

while better than nothing, leaves too many people behind for too long. I would also push for reforms that make vouchers actually usable in high-opportunity areas, where landlords frequently refuse to accept them, so that the program delivers on its full potential.	do just that. Rep. Maxine Waters' Ending Homelessness Act, which would make Housing Choice Vouchers an entitlement program. We need bold proposals like this to close the gap between housing need and available assistance. I will continue working to expand and strengthen Section 8 Vouchers until every family has access to the assistance they need to maintain a decent quality of life.
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Q3 The largest cost for most American families is housing; the second largest is their car. With the price of both going up rapidly, what are some tools the federal government can use to encourage the development of more mass transit and housing near transit? Would you support federal legislation that would tie federal funding for transit improvements to transit-oriented development near transit projects that receive federal funds as a carrot-and-stick incentive?	
Ali ✓ Support	Menendez ✓ Support
MUSSAB ALI Housing and transportation costs together represent the two largest financial burdens on most American families. Federal policy has for too long treated them in silos. I strongly support tying federal	REP. ROB MENENDEZ JR. The idea that housing and transit should reinforce one another has the potential to improve many of the challenges working families face, especially when paired with safeguards to protect

transit funding to transit-oriented development as both a carrot and a stick. When the federal government invests in a transit project, the surrounding land use should reflect that investment. Walkable, mixed-income, higher-density housing that reduces car dependency and lowers the combined cost burden for working families should be required. My platform explicitly includes incentives for transit-oriented development, and I believe federal infrastructure dollars should actively reward communities that align their zoning with their transit investments rather than allowing those investments to be surrounded by sprawl or luxury-only development.

tenant rights and affordability. I believe the federal government can play an important role in encouraging communities to embrace transit-oriented development policies that they may not otherwise pursue. That's why I'm supportive of federal incentives to galvanize housing development in transit-served areas, including reforms that address density, zoning and land use, parking, and transit design. At the same time, I would be cautious about approaches that could harm communities already struggling to grapple with rising costs and limited fiscal capacity, particularly at a time when the Trump Administration is endangering many resources that our communities rely on.

At the end of the day, I'm open to carefully designed "carrot-and-stick" approaches, but I would evaluate them closely to ensure they encourage better alignment between housing and transit without unduly penalizing communities.

affordability by expanding low-income housing stock and increasing overall supply. However, housing advocates and legislators (including Senator Schatz who has ultimately opposed the bill after initially sponsoring it) have raised concerns regarding language that could inadvertently increase costs for families. Do you support the Act in its current form? If not, what specific amendments would you propose to address potential negative impacts?

Ali  Amend

MUSSAB ALI

I support the goals of the ROAD to Housing Act but the concerns raised by housing advocates and Senator Schatz about language that could inadvertently increase costs for families (by, e.g., disincentivizing institutional investors from constructing new housing in the first place) are serious and deserve to be addressed before passage. That said, any housing legislation must be evaluated not just by the supply it creates, but by who benefits and who bears the cost. I would work with housing advocates, tenant organizations, and affected communities to identify the specific provisions that create problematic incentives and propose targeted amendments to

Menendez  Amend

REP. ROB MENENDEZ JR.

I strongly agree with this bill's goal of increasing the housing supply and preventing the harms that can come from large-scale ownership. While many of this bill's provisions are urgently needed, I am also aware that some of the policies under consideration have the potential to generate unintended drawbacks and influence the availability of rental opportunities. Should the House consider this bill, I would be open to targeted amendments that ensure the bill expands housing opportunities for working families as intended. That requires policies that support both rental and ownership opportunities, maintain and build incentives for new housing

address them, ensuring the final bill delivers genuine affordability rather than supply gains that primarily benefit higher-income households.	new housing development, and keep costs low for families.
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SECTION II

Transit

Q5 The HBLR Northern Branch extension to Bergen County has been stuck in environmental review since 2001. In 2023, the FTA rescinded its 2007 notice of intent because the project had changed too much, which effectively reset the NEPA clock after 16 years of study. Do you support reforming NEPA to streamline environmental review for transit projects? Specifically, would you support categorical exclusions for transit projects in existing rights-of-way, statutory time limits on environmental review, or a "one federal decision" framework that consolidates reviews across agencies?	
Ali ✓ Support	Menendez ✓ Support
MUSSAB ALI The HBLR Northern Branch situation is a cautionary tale that should not be allowed to repeat itself. Having the NEPA clock effectively reset after 16 years of environmental review is just bureaucratic dysfunction that delays the very projects our communities need. I support meaningful	REP. ROB MENENDEZ JR. Communities can't benefit from projects that are never completed. Thankfully, there's bipartisan consensus that we need permitting reform to deliver new infrastructure faster and at lower cost. I believe we must provide developers and communities with

NEPA reform for transit, including categorical exclusions for transit projects in existing rights-of-way, statutory time limits on environmental review, and a "one federal decision" framework that consolidates reviews across agencies. Transit projects in established corridors pose fundamentally different environmental risks than greenfield highway construction, and our regulatory framework should reflect that distinction. Streamlining review for transit is also a climate imperative: every year of delay on projects like the Northern Branch extension is another year of car dependency and emissions that could have been avoided.

greater certainty to help move projects more efficiently while preserving robust environmental reviews that protect overburdened communities.

That's why I voted for the Fiscal Responsibility Act, which established statutory deadlines of two years for Environmental Impact Statements and one year for Environmental Assessments, and codified the principles of the "One Federal Decision" framework. I also recognize that delays in environmental review extend beyond NEPA itself and stem from the broader web of statutes that govern major projects. I cosponsored the Energy Bills Relief Act, which would improve interagency coordination through an interconnected environmental data system to standardize information across agencies, project sponsors, and the public.

I never lose sight of the fact that our district is on the frontlines of climate change and environmental justice. Many of our communities are near overburdened

	overburdened infrastructure and one of the most polluted rivers in the country, and they have borne the cumulative impacts of decades of environmental harm. I strongly believe in the underlying value of NEPA and environmental review, and while I support targeted reforms to improve efficiency, I am generally opposed to categorical exclusions that would completely bypass meaningful environmental analysis. We don't have to choose between building infrastructure and protecting our communities — we just need a permitting process that allows for both.
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Q6 Tens of thousands of residents in Hudson County, Newark, and Elizabeth rely on the bus. Do you support dedicated federal funding for Bus Rapid Transit? Would you advocate for BRT on JFK Boulevard in Hudson County to receive FTA Capital Investment Grant funding? Would you revive a similar proposal to link Elizabeth and Newark by BRT or light rail?	
Ali ✓ Support	Menendez ✓ Support
MUSSAB ALI Tens of thousands of Hudson County residents depend on the bus every day, and	REP. ROB MENENDEZ JR. Buses are the backbone of our transit system. Tens of

they deserve the same federal investment attention as rail projects. I fully support dedicated federal funding for Bus Rapid Transit and would actively advocate for BRT on JFK Boulevard in Hudson County to receive FTA Capital Investment Grant funding. JFK Boulevard is a heavily traveled corridor where dedicated bus infrastructure could dramatically improve reliability and speed for working commuters. During my 2025 mayoral campaign, fast and fare-free buses with signal priority on dedicated lanes was a centerpiece of my transit platform, and that commitment has not changed. I would also support reviving a proposal to link Elizabeth and Newark by BRT or light rail—these are dense, transit-dependent communities that deserve better connectivity and should not be left out of regional transit investment.

thousands of residents in our district rely on them every day to get to work, school, and essential services. That's why I support Bus Rapid Transit (BRT) and believe we should fully leverage programs like the Federal Transit Administration Capital Investment Grants to deliver faster, more reliable service. I am happy to support a BRT project along JFK Boulevard, as well as a strong proposal to better connect Elizabeth and Newark through high-quality transit. Since taking office, I've prioritized investing in modern, efficient bus and transit infrastructure to lower transportation costs, reduce congestion, and increase access to transit opportunities. I'll continue to partner with our local entities to bring federal dollars back to the district and champion projects that deliver real improvements for the people who rely on transit most.

Q7 PATH is operated by the Port Authority and is regulated by the Federal Railroad Administration like commuter railroads such as NJ Transit. Most subways are regulated by the Federal Transit Administration. This

the Federal Transit Administration. This difference puts the PATH under stricter safety standards than the MTA and results in much higher operating costs and less frequent off-peak and weekend service. Do you believe PATH should be brought under FTA oversight like its neighboring system in New York City?		
Ali ✓ FTA		Menendez ✓ FTA*
MUSSAB ALI Bringing PATH under FTA oversight is a common-sense reform that would reduce operating costs, allow for more frequent off-peak and weekend service, and align PATH's regulatory framework with the subway systems it effectively functions alongside. The current arrangement—where PATH is regulated by the FRA like a commuter railroad while operating like an urban subway—creates unnecessary cost burdens and service limitations that directly harm NJ-08 commuters. Thousands of our residents depend on PATH for their daily commutes, and they deserve a system that is regulated in a way that enables the kind of frequent, reliable service that makes transit a genuine alternative to driving.		REP. ROB MENENDEZ JR. PATH plays a critical role in connecting communities across the Hudson River, and it must operate safely, reliably, and efficiently. One of my biggest priorities in Congress is advancing modern and efficient mass transit systems, and I'm open to evaluating the potential benefits of reclassifying PATH to align it with other urban transit systems. Reclassifying PATH could offer meaningful improvements that increase flexibility and expand services for commuters. Since any shift in oversight would also affect labor classifications, work rules, and safety standards, I would prioritize close engagement with all impacted stakeholders, including labor unions, PATH employees, the Port Authority, and regional transit

	partners, to ensure any major changes are thoughtfully designed to benefit both workers and commuters. While these discussions will ultimately clarify my position, I am encouraged by the potential benefits of reclassifying PATH, and when we once again have a Democratic president, I am happy to engage with the Administration to advocate for the needs of our community.
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Q8	Penn Station is the busiest rail hub in the Western Hemisphere, yet NJ Transit and LIRR trains use the station as a terminal, a legacy operational constraint that severely limits capacity. Do you support federal investment in through-running infrastructure at Penn Station, allowing NJ Transit trains to continue through to Long Island rather than terminating at New York Penn? What role should the federal government play in advancing this?
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Ali ✓ Support	Menendez — No box checked
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MUSSAB ALI Penn Station's terminal configuration is a legacy constraint that artificially limits the capacity of the most important rail hub in the Western Hemisphere, and fixing it is one of the highest-leverage investments the federal government could make in	REP. ROB MENENDEZ JR. Penn Station is used by hundreds of thousands of workers, parents, small business owners, and other commuters every day. But thanks to bottlenecks and operational constraints, riders that rely on Penn Station have to deal with delays,
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could make it
Northeastern rail. I
support federal
investment in through-
running infrastructure
at Penn Station to allow
NJ Transit trains to
continue through to
Long Island rather than
terminating. The
federal government
should play an active
role in advancing this
by funding feasibility
and engineering
studies, providing
capital investment
through the FRA and
FTA, and convening the
relevant stakeholders—
NJ Transit, the MTA,
Amtrak, and the Port
Authority—around a
shared implementation
framework. Through-
running would expand
capacity, reduce
congestion, and
improve service for all
commuters who
currently face crowded,
unreliable service in
and out of Penn Station
every day.

congestion, and a
system that isn't
meeting demand. We
need to get serious
about improving Penn
Station's capacity, and
that requires bold and
innovative solutions.

Through-running is one
idea that has the
potential to create
capacity, cut
congestion, and
improve the rider
experience. Recent
feasibility studies have
identified challenges
associated with existing
designs to execute this
system. However, there
is debate over the
extent to which many of
these challenges
genuinely limit through-
running capacity. Any
future efforts would
need to evaluate
whether design
changes could enable a
through-running
proposal to better meet
our goals and manage
real-world constraints.
The federal
government can play a
central role in ensuring
further studies to
assess feasibility,
bringing all the relevant
partners to the table,
and fighting for federal
funding for future
projects. Since Penn
Station impacts our
entire region, I am
committed to
coordinating with the
New York and New

Jersey delegations to ensure addressing these issues remains a priority.

Q9 Regional planners have long identified extensions of New York City subway lines (particularly the 7 train to Secaucus and the C train across the George Washington Bridge) as high-value trans-Hudson investments. Do

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3 responses to "Ali and Menendez in NJ-08 Answer the Better Blocks Questionnaire"

1.  **Gabe** says:
May 5, 2026 at 1:05 pm

Is the green highlight indicative of anything?

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- o  **Eric Conner** says:
May 5, 2026 at 2:27 pm

No, it is just to make it more legible when on mobile. We alternated between questions to prevent bias from highlighting.

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2. **Hudson County Commissioner Candidates Respond to Key Issues** says:

May 28, 2026 at 7:34 am

[...] Ali v. Menendez [...]

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